

House of Commons

Climate policy and Canada's role in global emissions reduction.

Backgrounder Guide

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Director’s Letter

Dear Delegates,

Welcome to the Canadian House of Commons at SPAMUN 2026! My name is Isabella Wu, and I am incredibly excited to serve as your Director alongside my Chair, Charlie Sung, and my Assistant Director, Preston Chen. On behalf of the entire Dais team, I would like to extend a warm welcome to all of you. Whether this is your first committee or your tenth, we hope to create an environment where everyone feels encouraged to participate, challenge ideas, and engage in thoughtful and meaningful debate. We look forward to meeting all of you and seeing the discussions that will unfold throughout the conference.

This iteration, the Canadian House of Commons will be addressing the topic of Climate Policy and Canada’s Role in Global Emissions Reduction. Climate change presents Canada with a complex policy challenge, requiring consideration of environmental responsibility, economic development, energy security, and the interests of communities across the country. Canada has committed to reducing its greenhouse gas emissions by 40–45% below 2005 levels by 2030, 45–50% below 2005 levels by 2035, and achieving net-zero emissions by 2050. These commitments are supported by policies addressing areas such as carbon pricing, clean electricity, transportation, industry, methane emissions, and natural climate solutions.

As Members of Parliament, your task will extend beyond simply discussing the science of climate change. You will be required to consider how climate policy can be implemented within Canada's political, economic, and regional realities. Questions surrounding federal and provincial responsibilities, Canada's energy sector, Indigenous communities, international commitments, economic competitiveness, and the affordability of climate policies will all play an important role in your debate. Canada’s role in global emissions reduction also requires delegates to consider how domestic policy connects with international agreements and Canada's responsibilities as a participant in global climate action.

We strongly encourage all delegates to approach this topic with open-minded and solution-oriented perspectives. As Members of Parliament, you should strive to represent the interests and political positions of your assigned party while remaining willing to negotiate and collaborate with others. Effective parliamentary debate is not simply about defending one position, but about developing arguments, responding to opposing perspectives, and finding practical solutions through discussion and compromise.

Most importantly, we hope that this committee will be an engaging and memorable experience for every delegate. Do not be afraid to speak, challenge an argument, or introduce an idea that may not initially have unanimous support. Come prepared to participate actively, think critically, and, most importantly, enjoy the experience of parliamentary debate. If you have any questions

leading up to the conference, please feel free to reach out to us at (add comm email here idk what it is).

Position papers are due on October 16th, 10 PM for final submission. Please submit your position papers to hocspamun@southpointe.ca, including your full name and delegation. If you encounter any circumstances that may affect your ability to meet the deadline, please do not hesitate to contact us.

We are incredibly excited to meet all of you and cannot wait to see the debates, negotiations, and ideas that you bring to the House of Commons. Until then, best of luck with your preparation, and we look forward to seeing you at SPAMUN 2026!

Sincerely,
Isabella Wu

Committee Description

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Topic Overview

The topic of Climate Change is an essential issue that continues to shape the discourse within the national and international spheres of the Canadian House of Commons. Being one of the highest-income countries endowed with abundant natural resources, Canada is obliged to take up a leading role in reducing global emissions. Canada seeks to reduce emissions by implementing various policies, including carbon pricing, investment in renewable energy sources, and measures for climate change adaptation, all while growing economically and considering regional disparities.

Timeline of Events

1992 — Canada ratifies the United Nations Framework Convention (UNFCCC), the foundational international agreement establishing cooperation to stabilise greenhouse gas concentrations and prevent dangerous human interference with the climate.

December 11, 1997 — The Kyoto protocol is adopted under the UNFCCC. It establishes legally binding emissions targets for a group of developed countries for the 2008-2012 period.

December 17, 2002 — Canada ratifies the Kyoto Protocol. Canada later struggles to meet the Kyoto target, which becomes a significant part of the country's climate-policy history.

2005 — Canada’s greenhouse gas emissions are approximately 763 Mt CO2e. Canada later adopts 2005 as the baseline year for its Paris Agreement targets.

2007 — Canada announces a target to reduce emissions 20% below 2006 levels by 2020 and later moves toward a 2005-based framework.

2009 — Canada commits under the Copenhagen Accord to reduce emissions 17% below 2005 levels by 2020.

December 15, 2011 — Canada announces that it will withdraw from the Kyoto Protocol.

December 12, 2015 — Canada submits its initial Paris Agreement target, a 30% reduction in emissions below 2005 levels by 2030. The Paris Agreement is adopted in December.

October 5, 2016 — Canada ratifies the Paris Agreement. The agreement enters into force on November 4.

December 9, 2016 — The federal government publishes the Pan-Canadian Framework on Clean Growth and Climate Change, establishing a broad national approach that includes carbon pricing, clean technology, transportation, buildings, and adaptation.

June 21, 2018 — The federal government introduces the Greenhouse Gas Pollution Pricing Act, establishing a federal carbon-pricing framework with a fuel charge for consumers and an Output-Based Pricing System for large industrial emitters.

April 1, 2019 — The federal carbon pollution pricing system begins to apply in provinces and territories that did not have systems meeting the federal benchmark.

2021 — Canada increases its Paris target to a 40–45% reduction below 2005 levels by 2030. Parliament also passes the Canadian Net-Zero Emissions Accountability Act, creating a statutory framework for five-year emissions targets, emissions reduction plans, and net-zero by 2050.

June 14, 2021 — Canada announces that it will provide $5.3 billion in international climate finance from 2021 to 2026, doubling its previous commitment.

March 29, 2022 — The federal government releases the 2030 Emissions Reduction Plan, which lays out sector-by-sector measures intended to reduce emissions 40–45% below 2005 levels by 2030 and put Canada on a path to net-zero by 2050.

2022 — Canada establishes an interim objective of reducing emissions 20% below 2005 levels by 2026.

December 13, 2023 — At COP28, countries complete the first Global Stocktake under the Paris Agreement. The outcome calls for rapid emissions reductions, a tripling of renewable energy capacity and a doubling of the global average rate of energy-efficiency improvements by 2030, among other measures.

December 12, 2024 — Canada announces a 2035 target of reducing greenhouse gas emissions 45–50% below 2005 levels.

November 24, 2024 — At COP29 in Baku, countries agree to a new climate-finance goal calling for developed countries to lead in providing at least US$300 billion annually to developing countries by 2035, alongside a broader effort to scale climate finance to US$1.3 trillion per year.

March 14, 2025 — The federal government announces that the consumer fuel charge will be set to zero effective April 1, 2025, and removes the requirement for provinces and territories to maintain a consumer-facing carbon price. Industrial carbon pricing remains.

April 28, 2025 — The 2025 federal election produces a House of Commons in which the Liberal Party forms the government. Climate policy remains contested over carbon pricing, oil and gas regulation, clean electricity, transportation, and energy infrastructure.

May 15, 2026 — Canada's industrial carbon-pricing trajectory is updated, with a national headline price trajectory of $95 per tonne in 2026 rising to $115 in 2030 and $130 in 2035, subject to the federal benchmark and provincial or territorial systems.

Historical Analysis

Early international commitments

Canada's climate-policy history predates the current debate over carbon pricing and net-zero targets. The country participated in the creation of the UNFCCC in 1992 and subsequently ratified the Kyoto Protocol. The Kyoto period demonstrated a recurring feature of Canadian climate politics: international commitments can be negotiated at the federal level while implementation depends on a country with substantial provincial authority over energy and natural resources.

Under Kyoto, Canada committed to an average emissions level 6% below 1990 during the 2008–2012 commitment period. Canada did not meet this objective and withdrew from the protocol in 2011, with withdrawal taking effect in 2012. The episode continues to influence debates over the credibility of federal climate commitments. Supporters of stronger federal action cite the history as evidence that targets require enforceable domestic policies. Critics can point to the same history as evidence that international commitments are difficult to meet when domestic economic and regional conditions change.

The Paris Agreement and the shift to net-zero

The Paris Agreement took a different structure from Kyoto. It established a framework in which all Parties submit nationally determined contributions, or NDCs, and progressively strengthen them. NDCs are submitted every five years and are informed by the results of the Paris Agreement's Global Stocktake.

Canada's first Paris target was a 30% reduction below 2005 levels by 2030. In 2021, the target was increased to 40–45%. The same year, Parliament passed the Canadian Net-Zero Emissions Accountability Act. The Act requires the federal government to establish emissions targets at least ten years in advance for five-year milestone years, prepare emissions reduction plans, publish progress reports, and maintain a framework for accountability toward net-zero by 2050.

The legislation matters because it separates the existence of a target from the specific policy instruments used to meet it. Parliament can set a long-term destination while successive governments decide how to regulate, tax, subsidize, or otherwise influence economic behaviour. That separation gives the framework continuity across electoral cycles, though it does not eliminate political disagreement about the policies themselves.

Carbon pricing

Carbon pricing became a central component of Canadian climate policy after 2018. The federal system was designed around two principal mechanisms. The first was a fuel charge applied to

fossil fuels used by consumers and businesses in covered jurisdictions. The second was the Output-Based Pricing System, which applies to large industrial facilities and requires them to compensate for emissions above facility-specific limits while allowing facilities that outperform their limits to earn credits.

The economic logic of carbon pricing is relatively simple. Greenhouse gas emissions create a cost that is not fully reflected in the private price of fossil fuels. A price on emissions changes incentives by making high-emitting activities more expensive relative to lower-emitting alternatives. Industrial output-based systems use a different structure from a simple tax because they are designed around emissions intensity and trade exposure, with the goal of reducing emissions while limiting the risk that production moves to jurisdictions with weaker rules.

Carbon pricing nevertheless became one of Canada's most politically divisive climate policies. Supporters argued that it provided a broad and technology-neutral incentive to reduce emissions, while critics argued that consumer-facing pricing increased costs for households and businesses. The federal government ended the consumer fuel charge in April 2025. The industrial component remained, and the federal government subsequently shifted its carbon-pricing framework toward industrial emissions.

Sectoral regulation and investment

Carbon pricing was never Canada's only climate instrument. Federal policy has also targeted electricity, transportation, methane, fuels, buildings, industrial technology, and natural resources. This reflects the practical reality that different sectors respond to different policy tools.

Electricity is particularly important because decarbonizing electricity can enable reductions in other sectors. Electric vehicles, heat pumps, industrial electrification, and some forms of hydrogen production can reduce emissions when the electricity used to power them is low-carbon. Canada already has a relatively low-emitting electricity system compared with many countries because of hydroelectricity and nuclear power, but the national picture varies sharply by province. Federal Clean Electricity Regulations are intended to move the system toward net-zero emissions while providing flexibility for reliability and regional conditions.

Transportation is another major source of emissions. Policies have included fuel standards, zero-emission vehicle measures, public transit investments, and infrastructure support. The debate over transportation policy often combines climate goals with affordability, charging infrastructure, industrial policy, and the availability of vehicles in rural and remote areas.

Methane has received increasing attention because methane is a potent greenhouse gas over shorter time horizons. Canada has regulations and programs aimed at reducing methane emissions from oil and gas operations, and the federal government has committed to further methane reductions as part of the Global Methane Pledge.

Oil and gas policy

Oil and gas is the most politically sensitive sector of Canada's climate policy. It is also the country's largest source of greenhouse gas emissions. In 2022, the sector accounted for approximately 31% of Canada's GHG emissions, according to Environment and Climate Change Canada. It is simultaneously a major contributor to Canada's GDP, exports, employment, government revenues, and regional economies.

The federal government proposed an oil and gas emissions cap in 2023 and published draft regulations in 2024. The proposed system was designed as a cap-and-trade framework. It would limit the number of emissions allowances available to covered facilities while allowing certain compliance flexibilities, including offsets and other eligible units. The proposal was designed to cap emissions rather than production.

The policy subsequently became a point of uncertainty. Parliamentary records from 2026 refer to the federal government's decision not to proceed with the proposed oil and gas emissions cap regulations. This change illustrates how climate policy can shift as governments balance emissions targets with energy security, investment, economic competitiveness, and changing international conditions.

Federalism and regional differences

Canadian climate policy cannot be understood without federalism. Provinces and territories control or influence major sources of emissions, especially electricity and natural resources. Provincial climate policies vary considerably. British Columbia has historically used a carbon tax, Quebec operates a cap-and-trade system linked with California, Alberta uses an industrial pricing system, and other provinces have adopted different combinations of regulations, taxes, and incentives.

These differences cut both ways. Provinces can design policies suited to their economies, but national emissions targets require aggregate reductions across the country. Federal standards can establish a national floor, but federal intervention may produce disputes over jurisdiction. Climate policy often involves equivalency agreements, federal benchmarks, fiscal transfers, and negotiations between Ottawa and provincial governments.

Indigenous peoples and climate policy

Indigenous peoples are affected by climate change and climate policy in distinct ways. Many Indigenous communities are located in northern, rural, and remote regions where climate impacts can directly affect housing, transportation, food systems, infrastructure, and traditional activities. Indigenous governments and organizations are also involved in renewable energy, conservation, land stewardship, and resource development.

The Canadian Net-Zero Emissions Accountability framework requires consideration of Indigenous Knowledge in the climate accountability process, and internationally, the Paris Agreement recognizes the importance of Indigenous peoples' rights and participation. Climate policy raises questions about consultation, consent, economic participation, Indigenous-led projects, and the distribution of climate finance.

Current Situation

As of September 2026, Canada's climate policy is in a period of transition. The country's statutory and international targets remain ambitious relative to recent emissions trends, but several of the policy instruments associated with the previous federal climate framework have been changed, delayed, or reconsidered.

Emissions and the 2030 gap

Canada's official 2024 emissions were 685 Mt CO2e, down 10.3% from 2005. The 2025 progress assessment projects approximately a 21% reduction below 2005 by 2030 under measures currently in place, and approximately 28% under a scenario that includes additional announced measures. The 2030 statutory target is 40–45% below 2005.

The difference between these trajectories and the target is central to the committee's work. Closing the gap would require either stronger existing measures, new measures, faster implementation, greater use of emissions removals, or some combination. It also raises the question of how much confidence should be placed in technologies or future policies that have not yet been deployed at the required scale.

The end of the consumer carbon price

The federal fuel charge was set to zero on April 1, 2025, and the requirement for provinces and territories to maintain a consumer-facing carbon price was removed. The government described the change as a refocusing of carbon pricing on industrial emissions.

The change does not mean that carbon pricing has disappeared from Canadian climate policy. Industrial carbon pricing remains in place through provincial systems and the federal Output-Based Pricing System, with the federal benchmark updated in 2026. The new headline trajectory is $95 per tonne in 2026, $100 in 2027–2029, $115 in 2030, and $130 in 2035, with further inflationary increases later.

The policy question is no longer simply whether Canada should have a carbon price. The more specific questions are what emissions should be priced, how stringent the industrial systems should be, how competitiveness should be protected, how revenues should be used, and whether carbon pricing should be complemented or replaced by direct regulation.

Clean electricity

Canada finalized its Clean Electricity Regulations in 2024. The regulations establish emissions requirements for electricity generating units, with different provisions and flexibilities for existing, planned, and new units. The federal government argues that a cleaner electricity grid will be necessary as demand rises due to electrification of transportation, buildings, and industry.

Electricity policy sits at an important intersection of climate and industrial strategy. A rapid increase in electricity demand can support electrification but requires investment in generation, transmission, storage, interprovincial connections, and system reliability. Provinces with large hydroelectric or nuclear systems have different starting points from provinces that rely more heavily on natural gas or coal.

Oil and gas and energy security

Oil and gas remain central to the Canadian economy. The sector's emissions profile puts climate targets directly at odds with the short-term economic importance of fossil-fuel production. The federal government's proposed emissions cap would have addressed the emissions side of this conflict, but parliamentary records in 2026 indicate that the government decided not to proceed with the proposed cap regulations.

At the same time, the federal government continues to pursue methane reductions, industrial carbon pricing, clean fuels, carbon capture incentives, and other measures affecting the sector. This leaves open a broader policy question: whether Canada should reduce emissions primarily by reducing the emissions intensity of production, reducing total production, shifting investment toward other sectors, or combining these approaches.

Climate competitiveness

Climate policy is increasingly connected to trade and industrial competitiveness. Major trading partners are introducing clean-energy subsidies, carbon standards, supply-chain requirements, and border measures, and Canadian companies can face pressure to reduce the carbon intensity of exported products even when Canadian domestic policy does not directly require it.

The federal government has increasingly used the language of 'climate competitiveness' to describe policies that combine emissions reduction with industrial investment. Examples include clean technology investment tax credits, critical-mineral development, clean electricity, low-carbon fuels, carbon capture, and sustainable jobs programs. The economic argument is that climate policy can reduce future exposure to carbon constraints while creating industries that benefit from the global clean-energy transition.

Adaptation and climate resilience

Mitigation does not prevent all climate impacts. Canada is already experiencing increased risks from wildfires, flooding, extreme heat, drought, coastal erosion, and other hazards. Adaptation policy includes resilient infrastructure, wildfire prevention, flood protection, building standards, emergency management, insurance, ecosystem restoration, and support for communities affected by disasters.

The federal government's climate plan includes a national adaptation strategy and programs aimed at infrastructure and resilience. Climate adaptation also has an international dimension, since developing countries often face substantial climate impacts despite having contributed a smaller share of historical emissions, which links domestic resilience spending to Canada's role in international climate finance.

UN/International Involvement

United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change

The UNFCCC is the principal international framework for climate negotiations. Adopted in 1992, it provides the institutional foundation for annual Conferences of the Parties, or COPs. Canada is a Party to the Convention and submits national greenhouse gas inventories according to international reporting requirements.

The UNFCCC does not require every country to use the same domestic policies. Instead, it establishes principles, reporting systems, negotiation processes, and agreements that allow governments to coordinate action. International diplomacy matters a great deal for Canada as a result, because Canada's domestic choices are evaluated within a wider system of national commitments.

The Paris Agreement

The Paris Agreement aims to hold the increase in global average temperature to well below 2°C above pre-industrial levels while pursuing efforts to limit warming to 1.5°C. It requires countries to submit NDCs every five years and provides an enhanced transparency framework for reporting emissions and progress.

Canada's 2030 NDC is a 40–45% reduction below 2005 levels. Its 2035 target is 45–50% below 2005. Canada's domestic accountability legislation connects these targets to federal planning and reporting.

The Paris framework does not guarantee that countries will meet their NDCs. Its structure relies heavily on transparency, diplomatic pressure, domestic implementation, and progressively increasing ambition, so Canada's credibility in international negotiations depends in part on whether domestic policies appear capable of delivering the targets Canada has communicated.

The Global Stocktake

The first Global Stocktake concluded at COP28 in 2023. It assessed collective progress toward the Paris Agreement's goals and found that the world was not on track to achieve the required temperature outcome. The resulting decision called for a global effort to triple renewable-energy capacity and double the annual rate of energy-efficiency improvement by 2030, accelerate the reduction of methane and other non-CO2 gases, phase down unabated coal power, phase out inefficient fossil-fuel subsidies, and transition energy systems away from fossil fuels in a just, orderly, and equitable manner.

The Global Stocktake matters for Canada because the Paris system is designed as a cycle: the assessment of global progress is intended to influence each country's next NDC, and Canada's 2035 target was established in this broader context. The next round of NDCs will set an international benchmark against which Canada's future ambition is assessed.

COP29 and climate finance

COP29 in Baku in 2024 focused heavily on climate finance. Countries agreed to a new collective quantified goal that calls for developed countries to lead efforts to provide at least US$300 billion per year to developing countries by 2035, while all actors are encouraged to work toward scaling finance from public and private sources to US$1.3 trillion per year.

Canada's international climate finance program committed $5.3 billion for 2021–2026. The funding is directed toward clean-energy transitions, coal phase-out, climate-smart agriculture and food systems, nature-based solutions and biodiversity, and climate governance.

International climate finance raises several questions for Canadian policymakers. How much should Canada contribute? Should funding prioritize mitigation, adaptation, or loss and damage? Should assistance be provided as grants or loans? Should Canadian funding support projects that also create commercial opportunities for Canadian companies? And how should Canada demonstrate that its spending produces measurable emissions reductions or resilience benefits?

Methane and sector-specific international cooperation

Canada is also involved in international initiatives targeting methane. The Global Methane Pledge calls for a collective reduction in global methane emissions of at least 30% from 2020 levels by 2030. Methane reductions can have relatively rapid climate benefits compared with reductions in long-lived carbon dioxide emissions. Canada has included methane reduction in its domestic planning and international climate diplomacy.

Carbon markets and Article 6

Article 6 of the Paris Agreement establishes rules for international cooperation involving emissions reductions. Countries may cooperate through internationally transferred mitigation outcomes and through a mechanism for generating credits under international supervision. International carbon markets can potentially lower the cost of emissions reductions by directing investment toward lower-cost opportunities.

Carbon markets also raise accounting and credibility challenges, however. If the same emissions reduction is counted toward more than one country's target, global emissions could be higher than reported, so rules need to address additionality, permanence, double counting, monitoring, and verification. Canada's approach to international carbon-market cooperation is relevant to the question of whether Canadian reductions should occur domestically or be supported elsewhere.

Canada's international role

Canada's global role is not determined solely by its percentage of global emissions. Canada is a wealthy, technologically capable country with substantial energy resources, large forests, extensive land, and established research institutions, and its international influence can include diplomacy, finance, technology transfer, standards, clean-energy investment, methane reduction, conservation, and cooperation with major trading partners.

Possible Solutions

To be done

Bloc Positions

To be done

Discussion Questions

1. Should Canada maintain the legislated 2030 target of a 40–45% reduction below 2005 levels, or should Parliament reconsider the target in light of current emissions projections?
2. If the 2030 target remains unchanged, which sectors should be responsible for the largest additional reductions?
3. What policy mix should Canada use to close the gap between projected 2030 emissions and the legislated target?
4. Should industrial carbon pricing remain a central federal climate policy after the consumer carbon price has been removed?
5. How should the federal government balance industrial competitiveness with the need for rapid emissions reductions?

Additional Sources/Works Cited

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